

Noticing Differently: What Makes an Experience Aesthetic?

An original lesson plan inspired by **Antonia Peacocke's** the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* entry on Aesthetic Experience. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* or *Antonia Peacocke*. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aesthetic-experience/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Aesthetics

“When you pause to notice that a sunset is beautiful, are you having a fundamentally different kind of experience than when you glance at a stoplight to check whether it's red — and if so, what exactly makes an experience count as 'aesthetic' rather than merely practical?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Distinguish practical, function-driven perception from aesthetic attention, using specific criteria such as disinterestedness and attention to appearance for its own sake.
- Explain at least two competing philosophical accounts of what makes an experience aesthetic: attitude-based accounts (disinterested or 'distanced' attention) and value/object-based accounts (unity, intensity, and complexity of the experience itself).
- Apply these accounts to real-life cases to evaluate whether aesthetic experience requires art specifically, or can arise from any object, including ordinary and natural ones.

Materials Needed

- One plain, everyday object per group (an apple, a stone, a coffee mug) for the demonstration activity
- Handout summarizing the 'aesthetic attitude'/psychical distance theory and the object/value-based theory (unity, intensity, complexity of experience)
- Case-study cards describing 6-8 real-life scenarios (some clearly artistic, some ordinary or natural) for the sorting activity
- Whiteboard for recording the class's criteria list

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Look at It Twice

10 min

Give each group a plain object and ask them first to describe it purely in terms of its use ('what is this for, and how do you use it?'). Then ask them to spend two full minutes looking at it purely for its appearance — color, texture, shape, light — with no reference to function. Ask groups to describe what changed about their attention and whether the second way of looking felt different in kind, not just in duration.

Direct Instruction: The Aesthetic Attitude

15 min

Introduce the 'aesthetic attitude' family of theories: an experience becomes aesthetic when we adopt a disinterested stance toward an object, attending to it for its own sake rather than for what it can do for us or how it relates to our desires (a version of psychical 'distance'). Connect this back to the object demonstration — the second, function-free way of looking. Note the challenge: is 'disinterested attention' something we simply choose to switch on, or does it require the object to cooperate in some way?

Direct Instruction: Unity, Intensity, and the Object/Value View

15 min

Introduce an alternative approach that locates the aesthetic not just in the attitude of the perceiver but in features of the experience itself: a felt unity or coherence, an intensity of engagement, and a sense of the experience being complete in itself rather than merely a step toward something else. Contrast this with the attitude-based view: on this account, not just any object can support a genuinely aesthetic experience by attitude alone — the experience itself has to have a certain shape.

Small-Group Case Sorting

13 min

In small groups, students sort the 6-8 case cards (e.g., watching a sunset, solving a math proof, tasting a well-cooked meal, watching a football play unfold, listening to a subway busker) into 'clearly aesthetic,' 'clearly not,' and 'contested,' justifying each placement using the attitude theory and/or the unity/intensity theory. Circulate to push groups on their contested cases specifically.

Closure: Does It Require Art?

7 min

Reconvene and ask groups to report their most contested case. Push toward the essential question: must an aesthetic experience involve art at all, or can ordinary and natural objects support it just as well? Take a final class vote and ask a student on each side to justify their answer in one sentence.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Can you adopt a disinterested, aesthetic attitude toward literally anything — a pothole, a tax form — or do some objects resist being experienced aesthetically no matter how you attend to them?
- 2 If aesthetic experience requires unity, intensity, and a sense of completeness, does that mean a chaotic or fragmented experience (like a jarring piece of modern music) can never be aesthetic, even if it's clearly art?
- 3 Is watching live sport an aesthetic experience, a practical one (rooting for an outcome), or can it be both at once — and does calling it 'aesthetic' change how seriously we should take it?

- 4 Do you think aesthetic experience is fundamentally a different kind of mental state from ordinary perception, or just ordinary perception plus a particular kind of attention and evaluation layered on top?
- 5 If two people look at the same sunset and only one has an aesthetic experience, what does that suggest about whether the aesthetic lies in the object, the perceiver, or the relationship between them?

Assessment

Students write a short response identifying one experience from their own life that they believe was genuinely aesthetic, describing it using the vocabulary from at least two theories covered in class (disinterestedness, unity, intensity, attention to form), and explaining why an ordinary or practical description would have missed something important about it.

Extension Activity

Have students spend 10 uninterrupted minutes in a public or natural setting of their choosing (a park, a cafeteria, their own backyard) deliberately practicing disinterested attention to something they would normally overlook, then write a one-paragraph reflection on whether they were able to produce a genuinely aesthetic experience, and what got in the way if they couldn't.

Free to use, adapt, and share for educational purposes with attribution to Philosophy Commons. This lesson plan is an original work created by Philosophy Commons; it is inspired by, but is not a reproduction of, the credited course's actual materials.